
ENGINEERING DESIGN DOCUMENTATION

LAPTOP STAND

Preliminary Design Specification

Revision 0.1

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Rev.	Date	Description
0.1	September 2026	Initial preliminary design specification.

Design Reference

This section provides visual references for the intended design direction and the existing market context. These images are not engineering drawings and are not intended to define final dimensions or geometry. They serve only as preliminary design references.

Design Inspiration

The following images illustrate the general form, mechanism and aesthetic direction that the proposed laptop stand may take. The final design will be developed independently based on the requirements and engineering constraints established in this document.

Existing Market Product

The following image shows an existing commercially available laptop stand used as a market reference. Its geometry, mechanism and functionality may be studied for comparison, but the final design will be developed independently.



Figure 1: Reference concept illustrating the intended design direction.



Figure 2: Existing commercial laptop stand used as a preliminary market and mechanism reference.

Contents

Document Control	1
Design Reference	1
1 Purpose	5
2 Functional Requirements	5
2.1 Functional Requirement Summary	6
3 Dimensional Requirements	6
3.1 Dimensional Design Considerations	7
4 Load Requirements	7
4.1 Load Distribution	8
4.2 Design Loading Cases	8
5 Adjustment and Collapsibility Requirements	8
6 Material Requirements	9
6.1 Material Selection Method	10
7 Manufacturing Requirements	10
7.1 Manufacturability Considerations	10
8 Component Breakdown	11
8.1 Component Documentation	11
9 Mechanical Interfaces	12
10 Initial Mechanism Concept	12
10.1 Mechanism Design Objectives	13
11 Simulation and Analysis Objectives	13
11.1 11.1 Range of Motion Analysis	13
11.2 11.2 Static Structural Analysis	14
11.3 11.3 Fatigue Analysis	14
11.4 11.4 Simulation Software	14
12 Design Constraints and Open Parameters	14
13 Version-Control Strategy	14
13.1 CAD Version Control	15
13.2 Documentation Version Control	16
13.3 Revision Philosophy	16
14 Preliminary Design Requirement Matrix	16
15 Preliminary Design Philosophy	17
16 Next Design Activities	17

17 Conclusion	18
Index	20

1 Purpose

The purpose of this project is to design and manufacture a **lightweight, portable, compact and mechanically robust laptop stand** capable of supporting laptops in the approximate mass range of **2–3 kg**.

The design shall provide adjustable height and width while maintaining sufficient structural stiffness and stability during normal use. The stand shall also be designed with manufacturability and portability as primary considerations.

A preliminary factor of safety (FoS) of

$$\text{FoS} = 1.5\text{--}2.0$$

shall be used during the initial structural design and analysis stages. The final factor of safety will be established after the material, geometry, loading conditions and manufacturing method have been finalised.

The project is intended not only to produce a functional physical product, but also to provide a complete engineering design workflow covering:

- requirements definition,
- mechanical concept development,
- material selection,
- CAD modelling,
- mechanism design,
- structural simulation,
- fatigue assessment,
- manufacturing considerations,
- engineering drawings,
- physical fabrication and testing,
- and version-controlled engineering documentation.

2 Functional Requirements

The laptop stand shall satisfy the following primary functional requirements.

1. Support a laptop with a nominal mass of approximately **2–3 kg** without structural failure.
2. Maintain sufficient stiffness such that deflection under normal loading does not adversely affect laptop stability or user operation.
3. Provide **8 discrete height adjustment modes**.
4. Prevent or minimise sliding of the laptop during normal use.

- 5. Remain stable on a supporting surface during loading and adjustment.
- 6. Collapse into a substantially smaller configuration for storage and transportation.
- 7. Permit adjustment of the stand without requiring excessive force or complex tools.
- 8. Use a mechanical architecture that can reasonably be manufactured using accessible manufacturing processes.
- 9. Maintain functionality through repeated adjustment cycles.

2.1 Functional Requirement Summary

ID	Category	Requirement	Status
FR-01	Load capacity	Support laptops in the nominal 2–3 kg mass range.	Open
FR-02	Safety	Meet a preliminary factor of safety of 1.5–2.0.	Open
FR-03	Height adjustment	Provide 8 discrete height modes.	Defined
FR-04	Slip prevention	Prevent unacceptable laptop movement during operation.	Open
FR-05	Collapsibility	Allow the stand to fold into a compact configuration.	Defined
FR-06	Structural stiffness	Limit deflection to an acceptable level under design loading.	Open
FR-07	Durability	Maintain function over repeated adjustment cycles.	Open
FR-08	Manufacturability	Use practical and accessible manufacturing processes.	Open

3 Dimensional Requirements

The following dimensions define the initial design envelope.

Table 1: Preliminary dimensional requirements

Parameter	Preliminary Range	Notes
Height, h	2–10 cm	Adjustable operating height.
Length, l	5–25 cm	Preliminary adjustable dimension.
Width, w	25–30 cm	Final value TBD based on laptop compatibility and mechanism geometry.

All dimensional values listed above are **preliminary estimates**. They shall not be treated as final design constraints until the mechanism, laptop envelope, structural requirements and

manufacturing process have been evaluated.

Dimensional values may therefore change during subsequent iterations.

3.1 Dimensional Design Considerations

The final dimensions shall be determined based on:

- target laptop size range,
- required stability,
- height adjustment mechanism,
- width adjustment mechanism,
- hinge and pin dimensions,
- material thickness,
- manufacturability,
- portability,
- structural stiffness,
- and interference between moving components.

4 Load Requirements

The primary design load shall represent the weight of a laptop acting on the supporting surfaces of the stand.

The preliminary laptop mass range is

$$m = 2\text{--}3 \text{ kg}.$$

The corresponding gravitational load is

$$F = mg,$$

where

$$g = 9.81 \text{ m/s}^2.$$

Therefore,

$$F_{2\text{ kg}} \approx 19.62 \text{ N}$$

and

$$F_{3\text{ kg}} \approx 29.43 \text{ N}.$$

The nominal maximum static laptop load is therefore approximately

$$F_{\text{nominal,max}} \approx 29.4 \text{ N}.$$

The structural design shall subsequently account for the selected factor of safety.

The load is expected to act primarily through approximately **six contact points** between the laptop and the supporting structure.

4.1 Load Distribution

For initial analysis, the six contact points may be represented as discrete or distributed reaction locations depending on the geometry of the final support structure.

The actual load distribution shall be investigated during CAD and FEA development rather than assumed to be perfectly uniform.

Potential non-uniformity may result from:

- laptop mass distribution,
- centre-of-gravity location,
- support geometry,
- component deformation,
- manufacturing tolerances,
- and user-applied loads.

4.2 Design Loading Cases

The structural analysis shall eventually consider, at minimum:

1. nominal static laptop loading,
2. maximum nominal laptop loading,
3. loading combined with the selected factor of safety,
4. asymmetric loading,
5. loading at critical adjustment positions,
6. and repeated loading for fatigue assessment.

5 Adjustment and Collapsibility Requirements

The stand shall be capable of changing its operating configuration while remaining mechanically stable.

The primary adjustment requirements are:

- adjustable height,
- adjustable width,

- controlled discrete height positions,
- collapsibility for storage,
- and repeatable positioning.

The preliminary design shall provide

8 discrete height positions

while allowing the structure to collapse when not in use.

Height and width adjustment are initially intended to be achieved using hinged and sliding mechanical elements.

The final adjustment mechanism shall be evaluated for:

- range of motion,
- locking reliability,
- ease of adjustment,
- structural stiffness,
- wear,
- manufacturing complexity,
- and accidental disengagement.

6 Material Requirements

The stand shall primarily use a metallic material or combination of metallic materials capable of sustaining the expected loads with acceptable deformation and fatigue performance.

The material selection shall consider:

- yield strength,
- ultimate tensile strength,
- elastic modulus,
- density,
- fatigue strength,
- corrosion resistance,
- manufacturability,
- availability,
- cost,
- surface finish,

- and suitability for the selected manufacturing processes.

The material must be capable of carrying the design load for extended periods while also tolerating repeated loading and adjustment cycles without unacceptable permanent deformation or fatigue failure.

6.1 Material Selection Method

Material candidates shall be identified using an appropriate engineering material database.

The final selection shall be justified using a combination of:

1. mechanical performance,
2. mass,
3. manufacturing requirements,
4. cost,
5. availability,
6. and simulation results.

The selected material shall be recorded in the final design documentation together with its relevant mechanical properties and source.

Material selection: TBD.

7 Manufacturing Requirements

The design shall favour manufacturing processes that are accessible, repeatable and appropriate for relatively small-scale fabrication.

The initial manufacturing concept is based primarily on:

- sheet-metal bending,
- milling,
- drilling,
- cutting,
- and conventional fastening and joining methods.

However, the manufacturing process shall remain an open design constraint until the component geometries and material selection have been established.

The design shall therefore avoid unnecessary geometric complexity where possible.

7.1 Manufacturability Considerations

During CAD development, the following shall be considered:

- minimum bend radii,
- sheet thickness,

- machining accessibility,
- hole tolerances,
- pin and hinge fits,
- assembly sequence,
- component accessibility,
- fastening method,
- manufacturing tolerances,
- and material availability.

The final manufacturing plan shall be developed after the component architecture has stabilised.

Final manufacturing process: TBD.

8 Component Breakdown

The stand shall be decomposed into individual components such that each component has a clearly defined mechanical function, interface and manufacturing requirement.

The detailed component breakdown shall be maintained as the mechanical architecture develops.

The current conceptual architecture includes the following functional component groups:

1. Laptop support structure
2. Base structure
3. Height-adjustment arms
4. Cross-joint arms
5. Hinge assemblies
6. Sliding width-adjustment elements
7. Pins, axles and fasteners
8. Anti-slip contact elements

The detailed component list, individual part numbers, material assignments and manufacturing methods shall be developed in the subsequent CAD design stage.

8.1 Component Documentation

Each final component should eventually have:

- unique part identifier,
- part name,
- material,
- manufacturing process,

- primary dimensions,
- relevant tolerances,
- interfaces,
- loading conditions,
- and associated engineering drawing.

Detailed component breakdown: to be developed from the mechanical concept.

9 Mechanical Interfaces

The design contains several important mechanical interfaces. These interfaces shall be explicitly defined because they determine the load path and constrain the motion of the mechanism.

Table 2: Preliminary mechanical interfaces

Interface	Function
Laptop → Stand	Transfers laptop loading to the supporting structure while preventing unacceptable sliding.
Stand → Base	Transfers structural loads and provides the primary mechanical connection between the upper stand and base.
Base → Floor	Transfers the resulting loads to the supporting surface and provides overall stability.
Support Arm → Base	Provides a constrained pivoting connection and transfers load into the base structure.
Support Arm → Stand	Provides the mechanical connection required for height adjustment and structural support.

The final design shall ensure that all interfaces have sufficient strength and stiffness and that the expected range of motion is not restricted by unintended interference.

10 Initial Mechanism Concept

The initial mechanism is based on a combination of rotational and translational joints.

The preliminary joint architecture is:

The mechanism is therefore initially composed of

2 base hinges + 2 height hinges + 1 cross pin + 2 sliding joints

This represents the initial kinematic concept rather than the final mechanism.

The joint locations, degrees of freedom, travel limits, locking mechanism and physical dimensions shall be established during CAD development.

Table 3: Initial joint architecture

Joint Type	Quantity	Purpose
Base hinge joints	2	Permit folding and rotation of the primary structure relative to the base.
Height-arm hinge joints	2	Provide rotational movement for height adjustment.
Cross-joint pin	1	Connects the cross-joint arms and constrains their relative motion.
Width sliding joints	2	Permit lateral adjustment of the stand width.

10.1 Mechanism Design Objectives

The mechanism shall:

- provide the required eight height positions,
- permit controlled collapse,
- permit width adjustment,
- resist unwanted motion during loading,
- avoid mechanical interference,
- minimise backlash,
- remain sufficiently stiff,
- and be practical to manufacture and assemble.

11 Simulation and Analysis Objectives

Engineering simulation shall be used to validate the mechanical design before physical fabrication.

The primary simulation objectives are:

11.1 11.1 Range of Motion Analysis

The mechanism shall be evaluated across its complete intended range of motion.

The analysis shall verify:

- all eight height positions,
- width adjustment range,
- collapsed configuration,
- maximum and minimum geometric positions,
- joint travel,
- and absence of unintended interference.

11.2 11.2 Static Structural Analysis

Static structural analysis shall be performed to determine:

- maximum stress,
- maximum deformation,
- reaction forces,
- critical components,
- critical joints,
- and resulting factor of safety.

The critical loading configuration shall be determined from the geometry rather than assuming that the nominal operating position is necessarily the worst case.

11.3 11.3 Fatigue Analysis

Fatigue analysis shall evaluate the effect of repeated loading and adjustment cycles.

The analysis shall consider:

- cyclic laptop loading,
- repeated adjustment,
- stress concentrations,
- hinge and pin loading,
- and the expected service life of critical components.

The final fatigue requirement shall be established once an expected usage cycle count has been determined.

Required service cycle count: TBD.

11.4 11.4 Simulation Software

The exact simulation workflow is expected to involve the engineering software used for CAD, mechanism analysis and finite element analysis.

The final software stack shall be documented as the project develops.

12 Design Constraints and Open Parameters

The following parameters are intentionally left open at this stage.

These parameters shall be updated as the design progresses. Changes shall be tracked through the project's version-control system.

13 Version-Control Strategy

Git and GitHub shall be used as the primary version-control system for the engineering project.

Table 4: Open design parameters

Parameter	Current Status
Final stand width	TBD
Final height positions	Eight required; exact dimensional positions TBD.
Final length adjustment	Preliminary range 5–25 cm; TBD.
Material	TBD through material-selection study.
rr Sheet thickness	TBD.
Pin and hinge diameter	TBD through structural and manufacturing analysis.
Joint clearances	TBD.
Anti-slip material	TBD.
Manufacturing process	Preliminary sheet bending and milling; TBD.
Fatigue service life	TBD.
Final factor of safety	Preliminary range 1.5–2.0.

The objective is to maintain a traceable history of design development across all major engineering disciplines rather than only source code.

Version control is expected to cover:

- CAD models,
- assemblies,
- engineering drawings,
- LaTeX documentation,
- MATLAB scripts and models,
- ANSYS project files where practical,
- simulation data where appropriate,
- design calculations,
- supporting engineering files,
- and other project documentation.

13.1 CAD Version Control

SolidWorks shall be the primary CAD platform.

Engineering drawings generated through SolidWorks shall be maintained under the same project version-control strategy.

Large binary files and generated files shall be handled according to the project's Git storage strategy to prevent unnecessary repository growth.

13.2 Documentation Version Control

This LaTeX document shall form the central design documentation record.

Design decisions, requirement changes, material selections and major geometry revisions shall be reflected in the documentation as the project progresses.

13.3 Revision Philosophy

Major design changes shall receive identifiable revisions or Git commits.

The objective is to preserve the reasoning and evolution of the design, not merely the final geometry.

14 Preliminary Design Requirement Matrix

The following matrix provides a consolidated view of the current requirements.

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Table 5: Preliminary design requirement matrix

ID	Parameter	Requirement	Status
FR-01	Load capacity	Support a 2–3 kg laptop.	Required
FR-02	Factor of safety	Preliminary factor of safety of 1.5–2.0.	Preliminary
FR-03	Height adjustment	Eight discrete height modes.	Required
FR-04	Height range	Approximately 2–10 cm.	Preliminary
FR-05	Length range	Approximately 5–25 cm.	Preliminary
FR-06	Width	Approximately 25–30 cm.	Preliminary
FR-07	Slip prevention	Prevent unacceptable laptop movement.	Required
FR-08	Collapsibility	Fold into a compact configuration.	Required
FR-09	Width adjustment	Adjustable through a sliding mechanism.	Required
FR-10	Structural stiffness	Low deformation under design loading.	Required
FR-11	Durability	Survive repeated loading and adjustment.	Required
FR-12	Material	Metallic material with suitable strength, stiffness, fatigue performance and manufacturability.	TBD
FR-13	Manufacturing	Prefer sheet bending and milling where practical.	Preliminary

ID	Parameter	Requirement	Status
FR-14	Static analysis	Evaluate stress, deformation and factor of safety.	Required
FR-15	Fatigue analysis	Evaluate repeated loading and service life.	Required
FR-16	Motion analysis	Verify full range of mechanism motion.	Required
FR-17	Documentation	Maintain engineering documentation in LaTeX.	Required
FR-18	Version control	Use Git and GitHub for engineering project files.	Required

15 Preliminary Design Philosophy

The design shall follow an iterative engineering process rather than attempting to establish all final dimensions at the beginning of the project.

The intended design progression is:

Requirements → Concept → Mechanism → Material → CAD → Simulation → Manufacturing → Testing

Each stage may result in modifications to earlier decisions.

In particular, dimensional requirements, material selection, joint geometry and manufacturing methods shall be treated as coupled design variables.

A design change that improves one property may therefore require re-evaluation of other properties.

For example:

Reducing mass → lower section thickness → increased deflection → geometry modification

Similarly:

Increasing hinge compactness → smaller pin diameter → higher bearing stress → material / geometry revision

This iterative approach is intentional and forms a central part of the engineering design process for the project.

16 Next Design Activities

The immediate design activities following this preliminary specification are:

1. Finalise the functional component breakdown.
2. Establish the preliminary load path.
3. Define the degrees of freedom of the mechanism.
4. Establish the required eight height positions.
5. Determine the preliminary width-adjustment mechanism.
6. Identify candidate materials.
7. Compare candidate materials using engineering material data.
8. Develop the first CAD concept.
9. Define preliminary sheet thicknesses and pin dimensions.
10. Perform an initial range-of-motion study.
11. Identify critical structural components.
12. Perform preliminary static structural analysis.
13. Iterate the geometry based on simulation results.
14. Establish the manufacturing process.
15. Produce engineering drawings.
16. Fabricate and physically test the prototype.

The design specification shall be updated as major design decisions are made.

17 Conclusion

This document establishes the preliminary engineering requirements for the laptop stand project.

The initial concept is a compact, adjustable and collapsible metallic structure capable of supporting a 2–3 kg laptop with a preliminary factor of safety between 1.5 and 2.0.

The design incorporates:

- eight discrete height adjustment modes,
- adjustable width,
- a collapsible structure,
- anti-slip contact points,
- hinged support members,
- a cross-joint mechanism,
- sliding width-adjustment elements,
- and a mechanically stable load path.

At this stage, dimensions, materials, manufacturing methods and component details remain subject to engineering evaluation.

The specification therefore serves as a **baseline** from which the CAD, material-selection, simulation, manufacturing and testing stages can proceed.

All subsequent changes shall be documented and version-controlled so that the final design retains a traceable engineering development history.

Index

Index

Adjustment, 9

Collapsibility, 9

Components, 12

Degrees of freedom, 13

Design constraints, 14

Design iteration, 17

Design philosophy, 17

Design process, 18

Dimensions, 7

Engineering drawings, 12

Factor of safety, 8

Fatigue analysis, 14

Fatigue loading, 8

Fatigue strength, 10

FEA, 14

Git, 16

GitHub, 16

Height adjustment, 7

Hinge, 9

Interfaces, 12

Joint, 13

Kinematics, 13

LaTeX, 16

Load, 8

Load path, 12

Machining, 11

Manufacturing, 11

Material selection, 10

Mechanism, 13

Metal, 10

Milling, 11

Open parameters, 14

Part identification, 12

Prototype, 18

Purpose, 5

Range of motion, 14

Sheet bending, 11

Simulation, 14

Sliding joint, 9

SolidWorks, 16

Static analysis, 14

Static loading, 8

TBD, 14

Testing, 18

Version control, 16

Width adjustment, 7

Yield strength, 10